

The Human-AI Partnership Framework

A design standard for where human judgment belongs in the age of AI

HITL — Human-in-the-Loop — as an organizational design standard, not a safety checkpoint.

Every process in the enterprise has an optimal human/AI balance. Most organizations are letting that balance shift by default — driven by tool availability, cost pressure, and urgency — rather than by deliberate design. This framework introduces a structured methodology for designing, measuring, and governing the optimal level of human involvement at every level of the capability hierarchy.

Applied here to all 13 categories of the APQC Process Classification Framework v8.0, it produces measurable HITL maturity ratios from L4 activity through L3 process and L2 process group, up to L1 category — at five maturity levels from Undesigned (M1) through Leading (M5). Mixed-pattern L3 processes are rolled up transparently from their real L4 children rather than force-classified to a single pattern.

The central finding is consistent across all 13 categories: organizations are running **18-20 percentage points more human involvement than HITL design intent** at every level of the capability hierarchy. That gap is the AI convergence opportunity — measurable, prioritizable, and governable.

Beyond the raw taxonomy, select domains now expose a **value-stream lens** — HR, Supply Chain, Finance, and others — that regroups the same underlying L4 data around the end-to-end flows a business leader actually recognizes, without changing a single underlying number.

HITL Design Principle

This is not a technology problem. It is a design problem. Every process in the enterprise has an optimal human/AI balance. The job of HITL design is to find it, define it, measure it, and govern it.

SEE IT IN ACTION

13 PCF Capability Domains

Browse HITL maturity ratios across every APQC PCF v8.0 category — full L1 → L2 → L3 → L4 hierarchy, from L1 category down to individual APQC activity.

Value Stream Views

See HR's Recruit-to-Hire flow highlighted end-to-end — one of 13 domains now mapped to the business flows leaders actually recognize, not just the APQC taxonomy.

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■ Decision — Judgment & Authority ■ Knowledge — Synthesis & Interpretation ■ Document — Content Generation ■ Transaction — Rules-Based Processing ■ Exception — Non-Standard Resolution

★ M3 = HITL Design Intent baseline · Equal-weighted L3 → L2 → L1 aggregation · © Timothy P. King & Claude (Anthropic) 2026